Cuba's new leaders vowed to break the island's historic dependence on sugar exports. Sugar, Cuban anthropologist Fernando Ortiz had argued in 1940, meant foreign, colonial domination; it meant slavery and dispossessed workers; it meant dependence, backwardness, and underdevelopment. Many economists and other social scientists in the 1960s agreed. Cuban leaders vowed to modernize the economy and overcome the island's historic dependence by diversifying agriculture and by promoting industrialization. It was not an unprecedented goal – but Cuba intended to do it simultaneously with a Revolution that was redistributing the country's wealth and resources.

The Revolution would accomplish this by relying on two techniques: government distribution systems, ranging from land reform to rationing, which guaranteed that the poor got an equal share of whatever resources there were; and popular mobilization, which increased the availability of certain kinds of services even when resources were lacking. Education and health care were two areas in which human resources could, to a certain extent, make up for the lack of material resources.

The first years of the Revolution were characterized by an ethos of voluntarism and redistribution mobilized in the service of national redemption. While some Cubans objected, and left the country, many more were inspired by the opportunity to remake their society. The literacy campaign, the formation of mass organizations, and the reform of the health system marked this initial period of intense mobilization.

"The attack on illiteracy," Richard Fagen explains, was "not simply a technological or pedagogical problem. It was seen as a profoundly political effort, one tied intimately to the revolutionary transformation of society and the economy."[13] Illiteracy and lack of education meant silence, marginalization, and oppression. Mass education was a key means of overturning centuries of inequality and empowering the poor. The mobilization of some 250,000 urban Cubans, including 100,000 students, was also a part of the project of political education, or *concientización*, for the urban, educated sectors of the population who had lived in relative material comfort under the old order. The campaign "vividly demonstrated a fundamental and repeatedly stated value of Cuban society – namely, that revolution *equals* education." Banners